

Reader's decision brief

Marvel or DC: which to start with, and where

What the question can honestly mean, answered on six measures

September 2026

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What better means

Six things 'better' can stand for, and which of them the record can settle

1

Marvel wins on scale, DC per release: watch Marvel, read DC

Six measures of 'better', and where each one points, 2008 to 2025

\$32.5bn

Marvel Studios, 37 films

Lifetime worldwide gross

\$878m a film

\$11.8bn

DC live action, 25 films

Lifetime worldwide gross

\$470m a film

5 vs 4

Academy Awards won

DC leads on competitive wins

1 Scale is settled and it is not close

Marvel Studios has out-grossed every Warner Bros. DC release in every year since 2013 except 2020, when it released nothing.

2 Quality per release runs the other way

DC's films have taken five competitive Academy Awards to Marvel's four, from a third as many releases.

3 Entry cost decides the medium

A new viewer [starts on screen](#) with Marvel because the order is the point, and starts on the page with DC because its best books stand alone.

4 The answer reverses on two conditions

A reader who wants one great evening should take DC; a reader who wants a long ordered story should take Marvel.

Read this as two recommendations, not one: the screen answer and the page answer are decided by different evidence.

Four of the six measures are countable; two are judgement

What 'better' can mean, the basis each meaning needs, and who leads on it

Measure	Basis	Leads	Verdict
Commercial scale	Gross per release	Marvel	\$878m against \$470m
Budget discipline	Gross over budget	Marvel	DC missed three in five
Critical reception	Critic score	Marvel	Median 84 against 58
Awards	Academy Awards	DC	Five wins to four
Writing	No common basis	Neither	Judgement, not measured
Visual range	No common basis	Neither	Judgement, not measured

What it means



Four rows carry a number Gross, budget multiple, critic score and Academy Awards are published for every release on both sides, so the comparison can be checked.



Two rows carry none There is no common basis on which one publisher's writing outranks the other's, and a scored table would invent one.



The split is the finding Every commercial question resolves; every artistic question stays open, which is why the recommendation is about where to start rather than which is better.

DC's trinity arrived by 1941; Marvel's ensemble only in 1961

First appearances that still carry both publishers, 1938 to 1963



What it means

DC had the field to itself

Its three best-known characters were published before the war, and none was built to share a continuity.

Note: Marvel's first publication was Marvel Comics #1 in 1939, under the Timely imprint.

Marvel arrived as a line

Four titles appeared inside 23 months and referred to each other from the start.

The 23 years still show

DC's canon is standalone myth and Marvel's a connected cast, which decides where a reader can open each.

DC has restarted its universe five times since 1985; Marvel never has

Line-wide continuity relaunches at both publishers, 1985 to 2025

Relaunch	Year	Resets?	Cost to a new reader
Crisis on Infinite Earths, DC	1985	✓	Everything before is another continuity
Zero Hour, DC	1994	✓	A second start date inside ten years
Infinite Crisis, DC	2005	✓	Histories rewritten again
Flashpoint and the New 52, DC	2011	✓	Every title renumbered from one
Rebirth, DC	2016	✓	The New 52 partly undone
Heroes Reborn, Marvel	1996	✗	Four titles for a year, then folded back
Secret Wars, Marvel	2015	✗	Main line kept; a parallel line added

Meets requirement: The option meets the requirement. Yes; No; Not assessed.

Source: Publisher first-appearance dates and line-relaunch announcements

What it means

Marvel's main line has run unbroken since 1961

Its relaunches added parallel lines for new readers instead of erasing the one that existed.

DC has reset **five times** in forty years

Each reset makes the previous decade's books a different continuity, which is why a DC recommendation has to name an era.

This is the reason the page answer differs from the screen answer

Standalone books are DC's strength precisely because its shared continuity keeps being rebuilt.

Every claim here is a count or a citation, never an image

What this comparison can show, and the one thing it cannot

1 No artwork is licensed here

Both houses' characters and cover art are trademarked, so the frame beside this column holds a specimen image.

2 Commercial claims are measured

Gross, budget, release and award counts come from published records, cited on the page that uses them.

3 Artistic claims are marked

Where a page reaches a verdict on tone or writing, it says that [the verdict is judgement](#).

4 Scores sit between the two

A Tomatometer figure counts opinions, which is reception rather than quality.



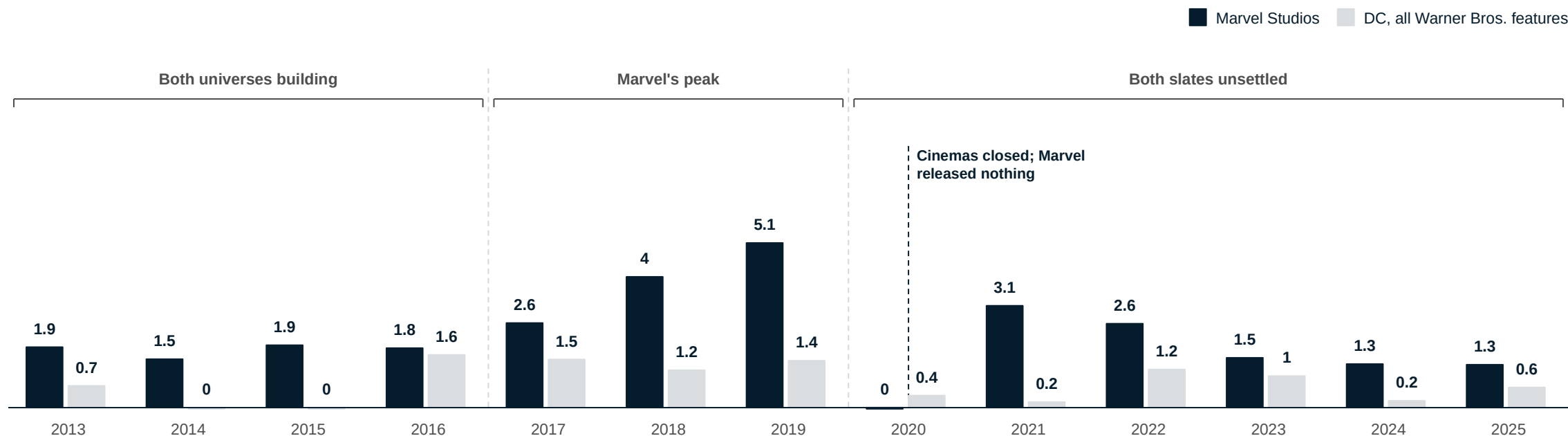
The commercial record

Gross, budget and cadence for both universes, 2008 to 2025

2

Marvel out-grossed DC every year since 2013 but one

Worldwide theatrical gross by release year, \$bn, 2013 to 2025



What it means

The one exception proves the rule

DC led in 2020 only because Marvel released no film at all that year, and Warner's two 2020 releases together took \$374m.

Marvel's peak was 2018 and 2019

Those two years alone took \$9.1bn, more than DC's entire thirteen-year run on this chart.

Both slates are now unsettled

Marvel has fallen back to roughly \$1.3bn a year and DC restarted its universe in 2025, so the current gap is narrower than the record.

Note: DC's series includes every Warner Bros. DC live-action feature, inside the shared universe or outside it.

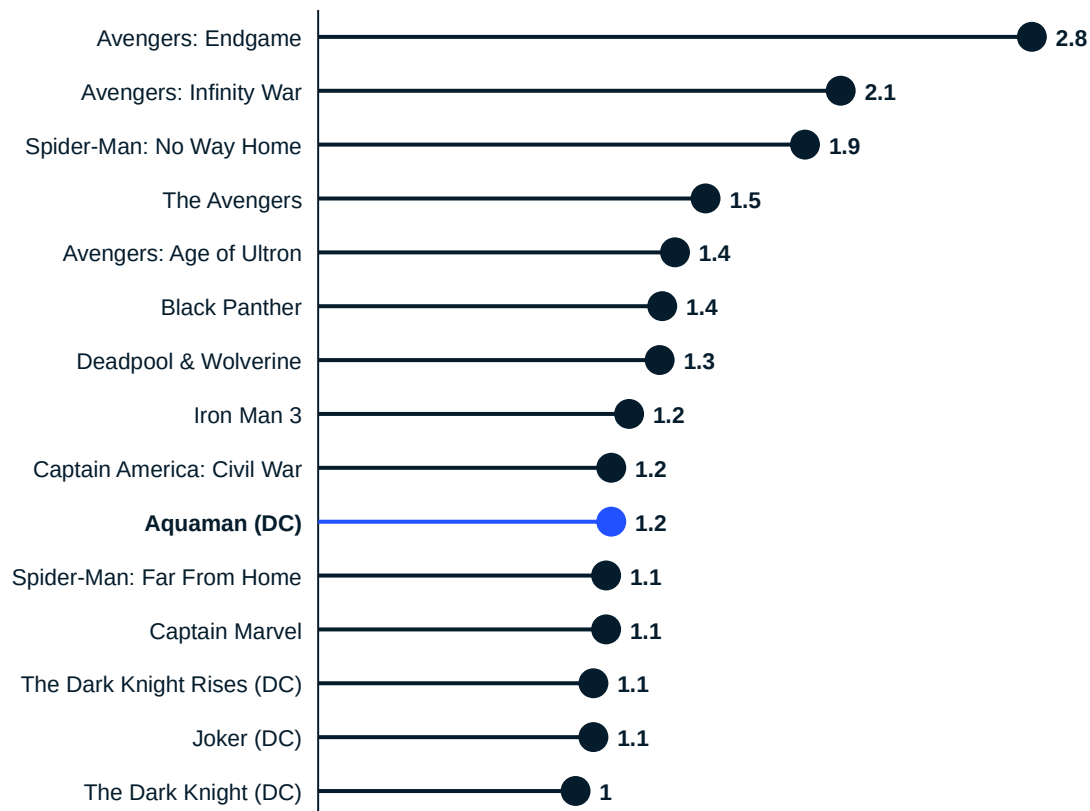
Source: Box Office Mojo, lifetime worldwide gross, unadjusted, September 2026

Marvel versus DC, reader's decision brief

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Marvel Studios holds eleven of the fifteen billion-dollar films

Comic-book adaptations above \$1bn worldwide, lifetime gross, all time, \$bn



What it means

Only four DC films have ever reached \$1bn

Aquaman, The Dark Knight Rises, Joker and The Dark Knight, against eleven from Marvel Studios.

Three of the four sit outside the shared universe

The two Nolan Batman films and Joker were made as standalone pictures with no connected continuity behind them.

Marvel's eleven are all one continuity

Every one of them depends on the films before it, which is the asset the gross is measuring.

DC's commercial ceiling is real, but it was reached by films a viewer can watch alone, which is the opposite of what a universe is for.

DC's biggest films were mostly made outside its shared universe

DC's eight highest-grossing live-action features, worldwide gross, \$m



What it means

Four of the eight are standalone

The two later Nolan Batman films, Joker and The Batman were made with no shared continuity and no obligation to any other release.

Aquaman is the shared universe's only billion

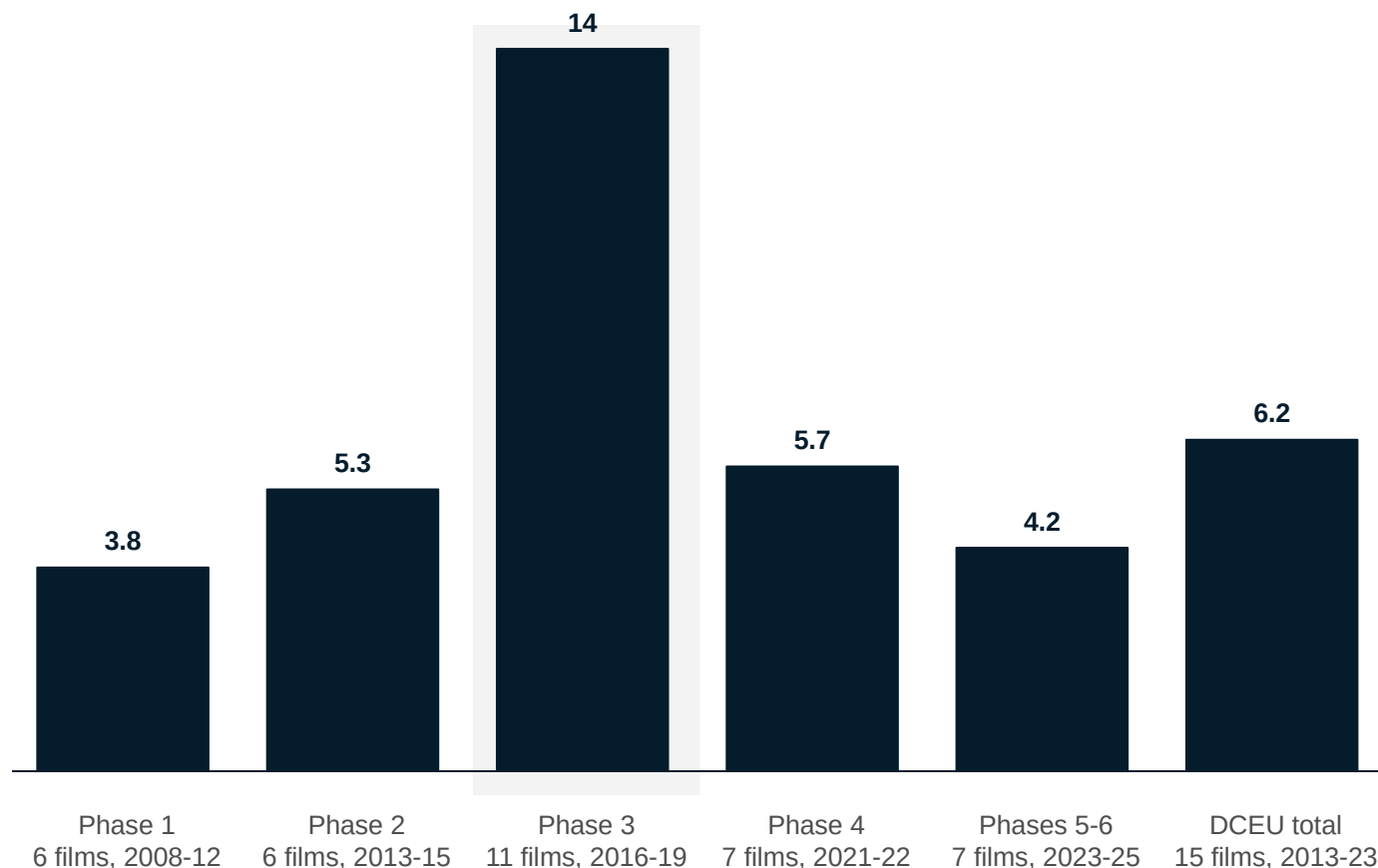
It is also the DCEU film with the least dependence on the rest of the slate, which is the pattern rather than the exception.

The lesson is about packaging, not quality

DC's best commercial results came when a director was given one character and no continuity to service.

Phase 3 alone took \$13.5bn, twice the DCEU's whole run

Worldwide gross by Marvel Studios phase, against the DCEU total, \$bn



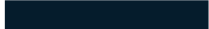
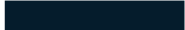
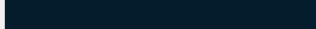
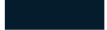
What it means

- 1 Phase 3 is the whole argument**
Eleven films from Civil War to Far From Home took **\$13.5bn**, including both Avengers films above \$2bn.
- 2 No other phase clears the DCEU**
Phase 2, Phase 4 and Phases 5 to 6 each sit below the DCEU's \$6.2bn, on similar film counts.
- 3 Marvel's lead is historical, not current**
On the last three years alone the two slates are within about \$400m a year of each other.

If the question is which universe is winning now, the honest answer is neither; if it is which has won, it is Marvel by one phase.

Nine of the DCEU's fifteen films missed the break-even multiple (1/2)

Reported production budget against worldwide gross, DCEU films, 2013 to 2023

Film	Budget \$m		Gross \$m	Multiple ¹ x budget	Verdict
Man of Steel	225		668	3.0	Cleared
Batman v Superman	250		874	3.5	Cleared
Suicide Squad	175		749	4.3	Cleared
Wonder Woman	149		823	5.5	Cleared
Justice League	300		661	2.2	Missed
Aquaman	160		1148	7.2	Cleared
Shazam!	100		366	3.7	Cleared
Birds of Prey	84		205	2.4	Missed

Gross (\$m, common scale 0 to 1500)

Read the multiple, not the gross

A film is usually taken to break even at roughly 2.5 times its production budget, because prints and advertising cost about what the film did and exhibitors keep about half the ticket.

Notes: 1. Gross over reported budget; the 2.5x rule is a convention, not an accounting result.

Source: Box Office Mojo; The Numbers

Marvel versus DC, reader's decision brief

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Nine of the DCEU's fifteen films missed the break-even multiple (2/2)

Reported production budget against worldwide gross, DCEU films, 2013 to 2023

Film	Budget \$m		Gross \$m	Multiple ¹ x budget	Verdict
Wonder Woman 1984	200		169	0.8	Missed
The Suicide Squad	185		168	0.9	Missed
Black Adam	200		393	2.0	Missed
Shazam! Fury of the Gods	125		134	1.1	Missed
The Flash	200		271	1.4	Missed
Blue Beetle	104		129	1.2	Missed
Aquaman and the Lost Kingdom	205		440	2.1	Missed

Gross (\$m, common scale 0 to 450)

Read the multiple, not the gross

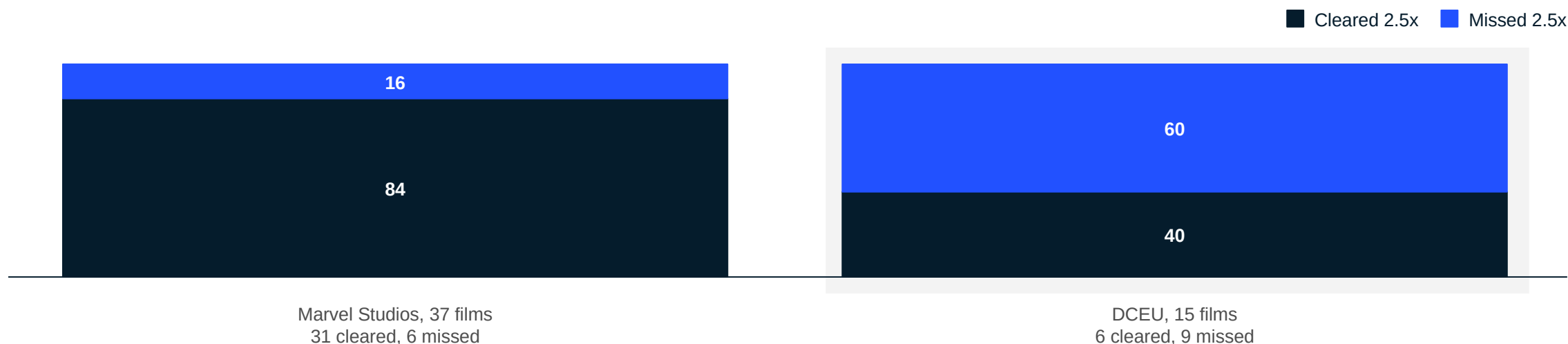
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Notes: 1. Gross over reported budget; the 2.5x rule is a convention, not an accounting result.

Source: Box Office Mojo; The Numbers

Marvel clears the break-even rule five times in six; DC twice in five

Share of releases reaching 2.5 times reported production budget, % of films



What it means

Marvel's misses are recent and small

Eternals, Black Widow, Quantumania, The Marvels, Captain America: Brave New World and Thunderbolts are the six, and all but one came after 2021.

DC's misses run the length of the slate

Justice League missed in 2017 and four of the last five DCEU releases missed as well, so this is not a late wobble.

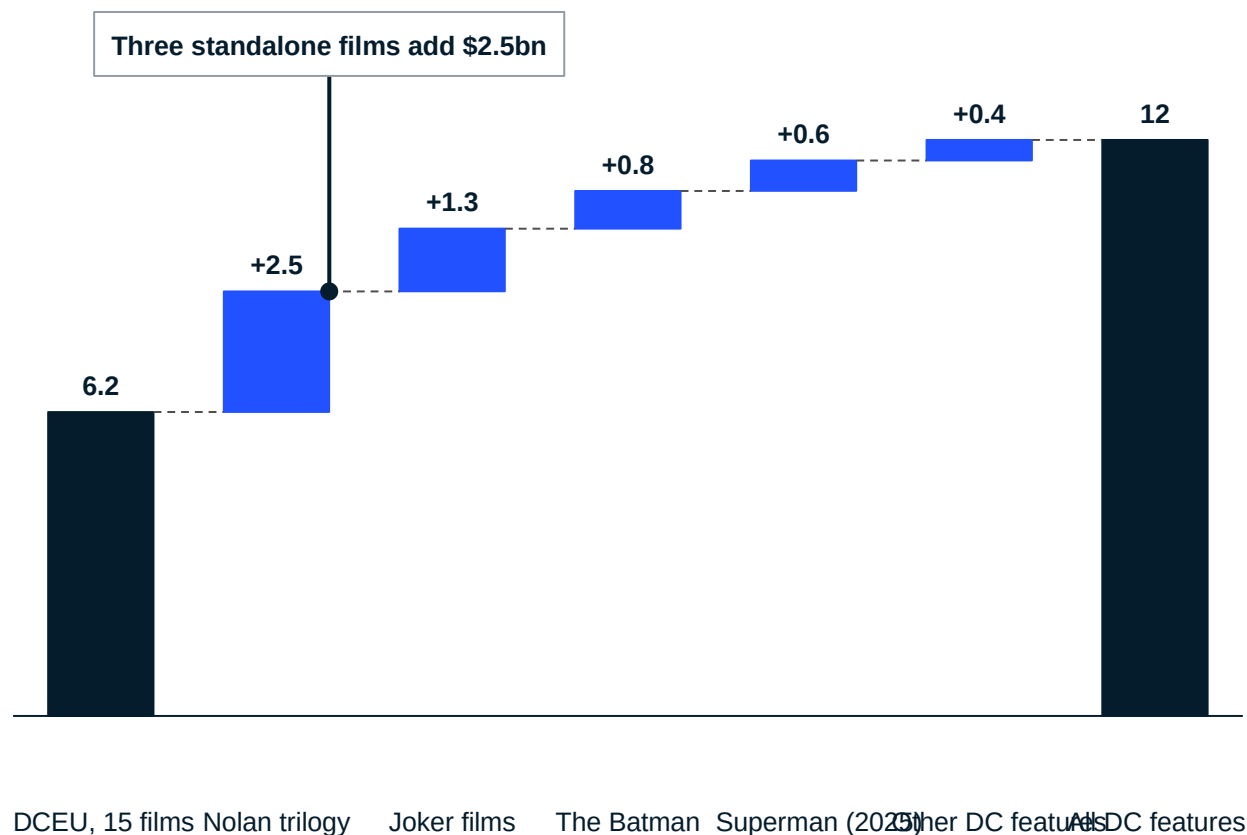
The measure survives the caveats

Even counting Wonder Woman 1984's streaming release as a clearance, DC misses on more than half its films.

On the measure a studio actually manages to, Marvel's advantage is wider than the gross comparison suggests.

Films outside the DCEU supply \$5.6bn of DC's \$11.8bn

DC live-action feature gross, 2005 to 2025, bridged from the shared universe, \$bn



What it means

The shared universe is barely half the record

Fifteen DCEU films took \$6.2bn; the other ten features took **\$5.6bn** between them.

Three directors account for most of the rest

Christopher Nolan's trilogy, Todd Phillips's Joker and Matt Reeves's The Batman add \$4.5bn on eight films.

The 2025 restart begins again at one

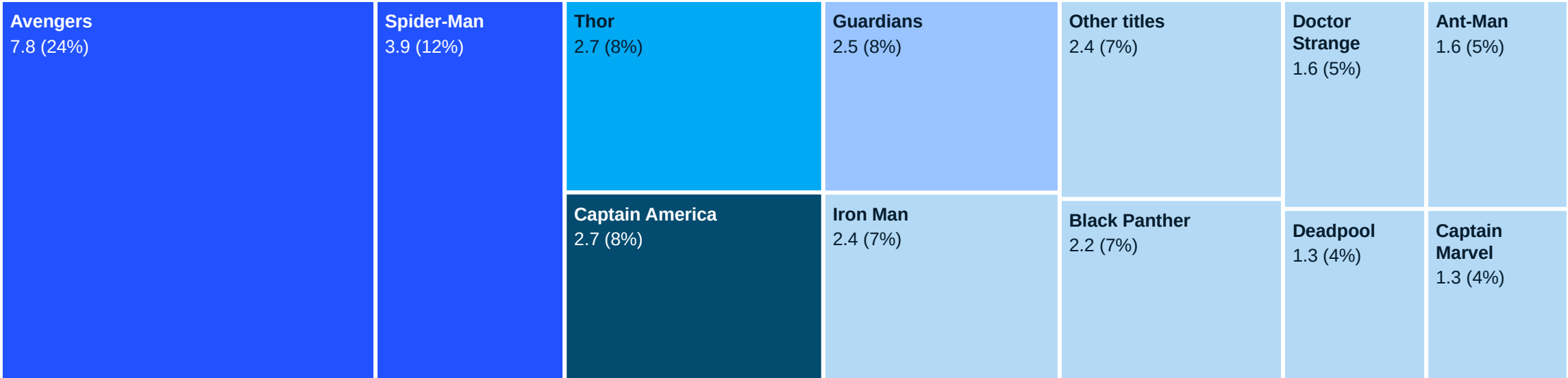
Superman took \$615m as the first film of a new continuity, which is a strong opening rather than a completed universe.

Note: Other DC features covers Watchmen, Green Lantern, Batman Begins and Jonah Hex.

Source: Box Office Mojo, lifetime worldwide gross, unadjusted, September 2026

The four Avengers films carry close to a quarter of Marvel's gross

Marvel Studios worldwide gross by character franchise, \$bn, 2008 to 2025



What it means

Four films, \$7.8bn

The Avengers, Age of Ultron, Infinity War and Endgame average \$1.94bn each, more than four times the average MCU release.

The crossovers are paid for by the rest

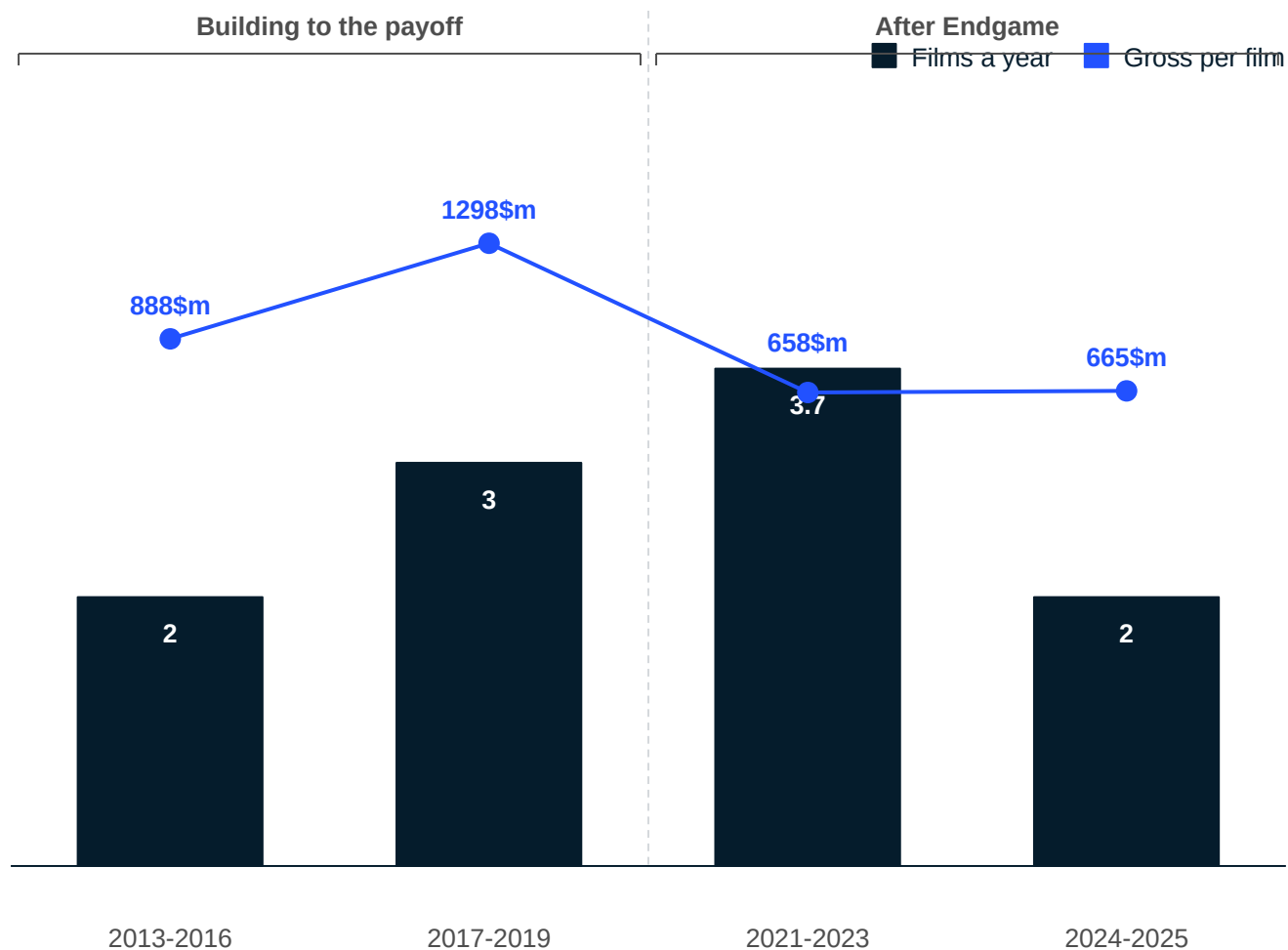
Nineteen solo films set up the four that cash the continuity in, which is what the shared universe is for.

No DC crossover has worked the same way

Justice League, DC's one equivalent, took \$661m against a \$300m budget.

Marvel's gross per film halved after 2019 as the release rate rose

Marvel Studios releases a year and average gross a film, four periods, Films a year; gross per film in \$m



What it means

- 1 The peak was 2017 to 2019**
Nine films averaged **\$1.30bn each**, a figure no studio has matched before or since.
- 2 The recovery period ran thinner**
Eleven films from 2021 to 2023 averaged \$658m, roughly half the peak, on a faster release rate.
- 3 The rate has now come back down**
Marvel released four films across 2024 and 2025 at an average of \$665m, so the correction is to volume rather than to quality of return.

Note: 2020 is excluded: cinemas were closed and Marvel Studios released no feature.

Source: Box Office Mojo, lifetime worldwide gross, unadjusted, September 2026

What the money settles, and the four questions it leaves open

Each commercial measure, what it establishes, and the condition that would change it

Measure	What it establishes	What would change it
1  Total gross	Marvel by 2.8 to 1 \$32.5bn across 37 films against \$11.8bn across 25 - The lead holds in twelve of the thirteen years	A different release window - On 2023 to 2025 alone the two slates are within \$400m a year - Two DC billion-dollar films would close a third of the gap
2  Gross per release	Marvel by \$460m a film \$878m against \$470m on lifetime worldwide gross - Marvel's median release also clears DC's best DCEU year	Counting DC's standalone hits - Including Nolan, Joker and The Batman lifts DC's average by \$57m - It still leaves Marvel ahead by more than two to one
3  Budget discipline	Marvel clears five times in six - Six of 37 Marvel films missed 2.5x; nine of fifteen DC films did - DC's misses run the whole length of the slate	Reported budgets being wrong - Studios do not publish audited budgets - Streaming day-and-date releases understate two DC films
4  Release cadence	Marvel sustained twice the rate 37 films in 18 years against 15 in eleven - Marvel has never had a two-year gap; DC had one from 2013 to 2016	The 2025 restart - DC's new continuity begins at one film a year - Marvel has announced a slower slate to 2027
5  Quality	Nothing at all - Gross measures distribution, marketing and habit as much as the film - The highest-grossing film of either side is not the best-reviewed	It is the wrong instrument - Critic and audience scores are the next three pages - Artistic verdicts are marked as judgement, not measured

The money settles scale, volume and discipline, and **it cannot reach quality**: the next two sections change instrument rather than continue the argument.

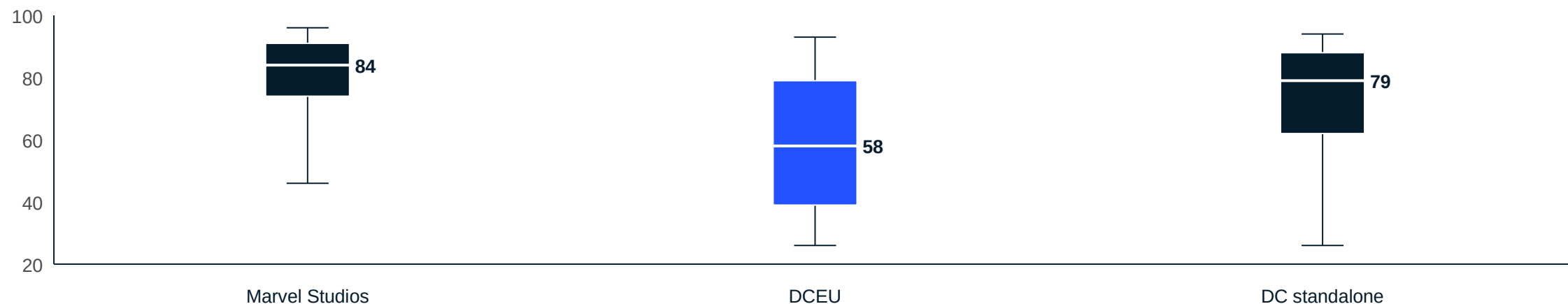
Reception

Critic scores, audience scores and Academy Awards on both sides

3

Marvel's median critic score is 84; the DCEU's is 58

Tomatometer distribution by universe, all theatrical releases, % of critics positive



What it means

The floor is the difference

Marvel's worst-reviewed release sits at 46 and the DCEU's at 26, so a viewer choosing blind risks far less with Marvel.

The ceilings are within two points

Black Panther at 96 and Wonder Woman at 93 are effectively the same result, so neither side owns the top of the range.

DC's standalone films score like Marvel's

Outside the shared universe DC's median rises to 79, which is the same pattern the commercial pages found.

A score is a count of critics' opinions, [not a measure of quality](#); what it settles is consistency, and Marvel is more consistent.

Both houses top out in the low nineties; the ceilings are equal

Best-reviewed features from either publisher, Tomatometer, % positive, % of critics positive



What it means

Six of the twelve are DC

At the top of the range the two houses are indistinguishable, which the median comparison hides.

Marvel holds the single highest

Black Panther at 96 is two points clear of The Dark Knight, a margin inside the noise of any aggregate.

The verdict is about variance

Marvel wins on the average release and **ties on the best one**, so consistency is the only thing the scores settle.

DC has won five Academy Awards to Marvel's four, on fewer films

Competitive Academy Awards for comic-book features, 2005 to 2025

Award class	Marvel Studios	DC features	Recognition	Verdict
Best Picture nominations	1 (Black Panther)	1 (Joker)	 Partial	Level: one nomination each, no win
Acting wins	None	2 (Ledger, Phoenix)	 Strong	DC outright
Craft wins	4 (costume, design, score)	3 (sound, make-up, score)	 Strong	Marvel by one, on nine times the releases
Total competitive wins	4	5	 Strong	DC by one, from a third as many films
Most-nominated single film	Black Panther, 7	Joker, 11	 Full	DC holds the record
Wins per ten releases	1.1	2.0	 Strong	DC at nearly twice the rate

Rating: 0 = None; 1 = Weak; 2 = Partial; 3 = Strong; 4 = Full. Missing = Not available; N/A = not applicable.

The Academy has rewarded DC's standalone films

Heath Ledger and Joaquin Phoenix both won for Batman-adjacent pictures made outside any shared continuity.

Marvel's wins are craft awards on one franchise

All four came from Black Panther and its sequel, for costume, production design and score.

Neither house has won Best Picture

Two nominations in twenty years is the whole record, and both are single films rather than a body of work.

If the reader's measure of better is recognition per release, DC wins it, and it is [the only measured question DC wins](#).

Joker and The Dark Knight lead on nominations; both are DC

Academy Award nominations by comic-book feature, 2005 to 2025



What it means

Two films carry DC's whole record

Joker's eleven nominations and The Dark Knight's eight are more than every Marvel Studios film combined except Black Panther.

Marvel's recognition is concentrated too

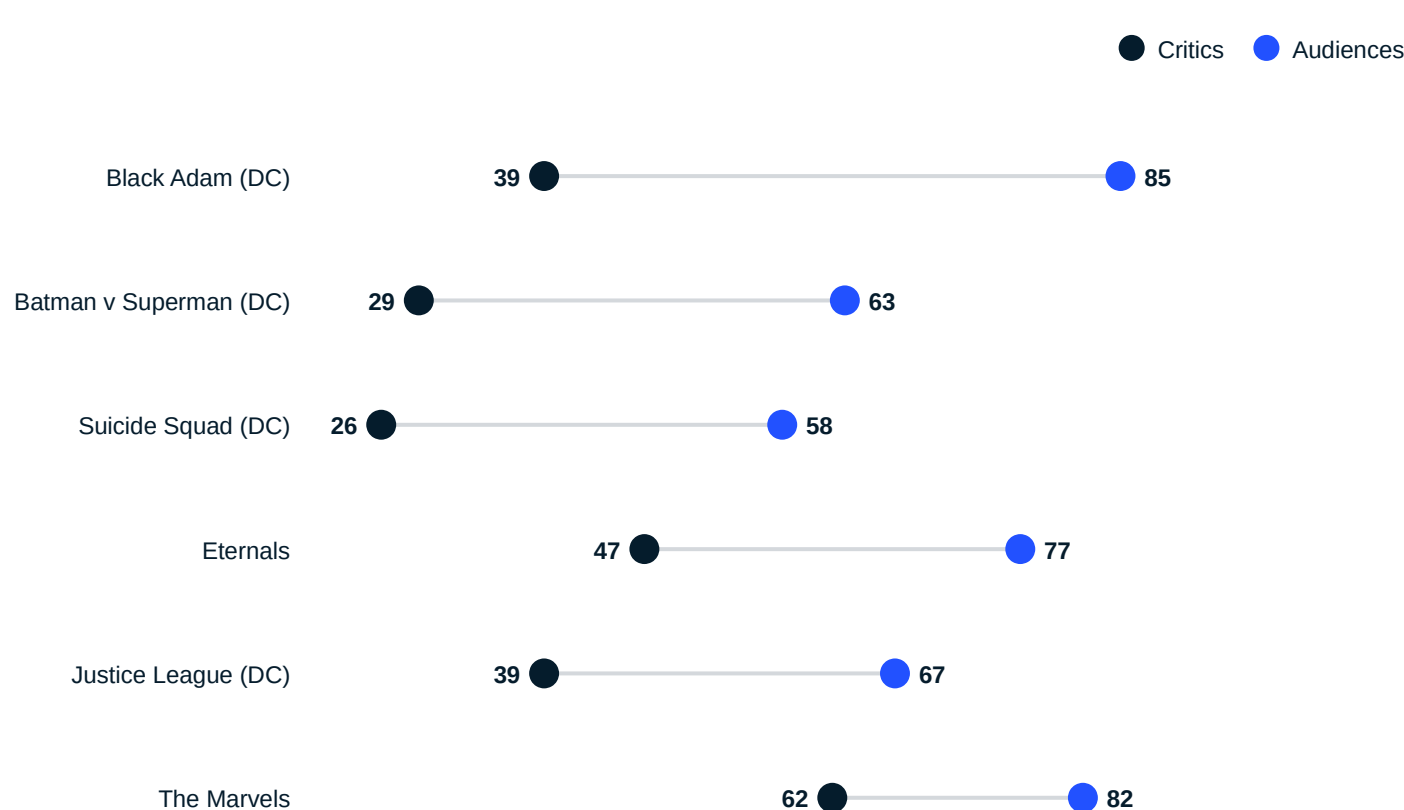
Black Panther and its sequel account for twelve of Marvel's nineteen nominations across 37 films.

The pattern is the same on both sides

Recognition attaches to a single authored picture, not to a slate, whichever house releases it.

Audiences rate the worst-reviewed films 20 to 46 points higher

Tomatometer against audience score, six poorly reviewed releases, % positive



What it means



The gap is widest on DC's Black Adam

Critics gave it 39 and audiences 85, a 46-point disagreement on one film.



Marvel's misses divide opinion too Eternals and The Marvels both sit 20 to 30 points below their audience scores, so this is not a DC phenomenon.



Which score you use changes the verdict

On audience scores the median gap between the two universes narrows to single figures, against 26 points on the Tomatometer.

Marvel's consistency advantage is real on critic scores and much smaller on audience scores, so say which one you mean.

What the scores cannot settle, before the argument turns to taste

Four limits that apply to every reception figure in this deck



Aggregates flatten disagreement

A Tomatometer figure is the share of reviews judged positive, so a divisive film scores the same as one everybody found adequate.



Release conditions move the number

Two DC films opened on streaming the same day as cinemas, which is not a property of the film but moves every figure after it.



Awards follow campaigns

Warner Bros. has campaigned for two DC pictures in twenty years; Disney has campaigned for one.



Aggregates hide the tail

A median across 37 releases says nothing about the two films a reader will actually watch.



Recognition rewards the exception

Nominations attach to single authored films, not to the slates a viewer chooses between.

Each figure counts something real

A critic wrote a review, a voter marked a ballot, a viewer left a score. None of them counts quality, and the difference matters for what comes next.

Treat the score pages as evidence about reception, and read the next section as one reader's argument, marked as such on every page.

The artistic case

Where no common basis exists, and the verdict is argued rather than counted

4

Marvel asks how a person copes; DC asks what a symbol owes

The organising question behind each house's best-regarded work

Marvel: people first

- Its 1960s line began with characters who had rent, illness and jobs before they had powers
- The best MCU films are about a person failing at an ordinary obligation under extraordinary pressure
- This is why the ensemble works: the interest is in how these people get along, not in what they stand for

DC: symbols first

- Superman, Batman and Wonder Woman were designed as archetypes before shared continuity existed
- Its best books ask what a figure that powerful owes the people it protects
- This is why DC's peaks are standalone: an argument about a symbol needs no other issue to finish

A reader who wants company should start with Marvel and a reader who wants an argument should start with DC; this is a judgement, not a measurement.

Three of four common tastes point at DC; the fourth carries the money

What a reader is usually looking for, and which house serves it

One great thing in one evening: DC

- The Dark Knight, Joker or The Batman need nothing before them
- All-Star Superman and Watchmen finish inside one volume
- Nothing in the MCU works this way above the level of Iron Man

A long story that pays off: Marvel

- Twenty-one films are cashed in by Infinity War and Endgame
- Sixty years of unbroken comics continuity to read into
- DC's equivalent has been reset five times since 1985

An argument about power: DC

- Its best books are explicitly about what a symbol owes
- Watchmen, The Dark Knight Returns and All-Star Superman are all one argument each
- Marvel's equivalents are rarer and mostly recent

Company and comedy: Marvel

- The ensemble tone is its own invention and it holds across 37 films
- Guardians, Thor: Ragnarok and Deadpool are the register at its best
- DC's attempts at it have been its worst-reviewed films

Why four rather than a ranking

A single ranking would have to weigh a completed argument against an accumulated world, and no common basis exists on which to do that. Splitting the audience instead lets every taste keep its own verdict, which is why three of these four quadrants point at DC while every commercial measure in section two points the other way, and why the recommendation names a medium rather than a winner.

The recommendation splits **because the audience does**, and the money follows the one taste Marvel serves best.

Marvel is built for continuity; DC is built for the single picture

What each house's structure produces, and what it costs

Two houses, two jobs: a continuous story against a series of arguments

What Marvel optimises

- One continuity, never reset
- A house tone every director works inside
- Crossovers that pay off the solo films

What DC optimises

- A director with one character and no slate
- Books that finish inside a volume
- Reinvention rather than accumulation

What each one costs

- Marvel: a weak film still has to be watched
- DC: nothing compounds between releases
- Both: the other house's strength is unavailable

The commercial record follows Marvel's structure; the awards record follows DC's

The structure explains both records at once

One continuity that is never reset makes a crossover possible and makes a weak film compulsory, which is what produces 37 releases at \$878m each and a median critic score of 84. A director handed one character and no slate can finish an argument, which is what produces eleven Academy Award nominations on a single picture and five wins in twenty years from a third as many films.

So **neither house can take the other's ground** without becoming it.

Five story dimensions, described the same way: DC takes three

The same question asked of both houses, with the verdict stated

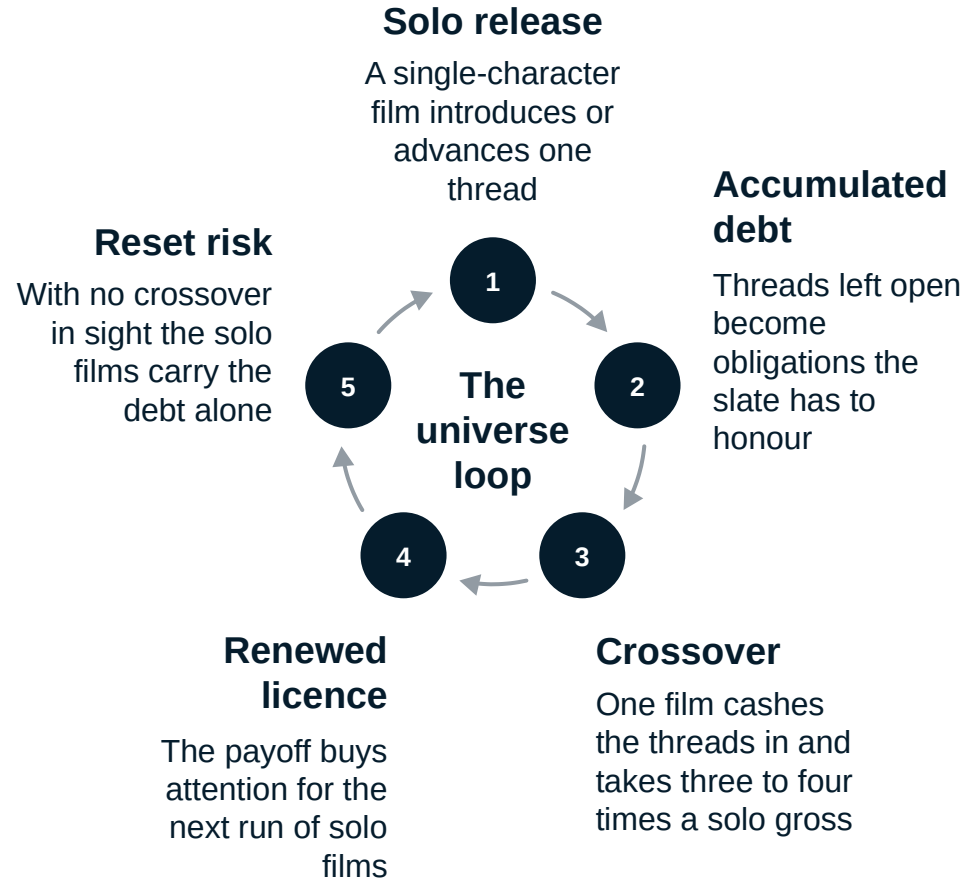
Dimension	Marvel at its best	DC at its best	Verdict
Stakes	One person's obligation	A symbol's obligation to all	DC for range
Humour	Built into the house voice	Used by exception	Marvel, clearly
Endings	Deferred to the next film	Delivered inside the book	DC, decisively
Villains	Mirrors of the hero	Arguments against the hero	DC, on two characters
Design	One look across 37 films	A new world per director	Marvel, for coherence

This page is judgement

No common basis exists on which one publisher's stakes or endings can be scored against the other's. The verdicts are argued from the named examples and a reader is free to reverse any of them.

The shared universe is a loop, and it stalls without a crossover

How solo releases and crossovers fund each other, and where the loop breaks



What it means

Marvel ran the loop twice

The Avengers in 2012 and Endgame in 2019 each cashed in a run of solo films, and the two took \$4.3bn between them.

The loop has been open since 2019

Marvel's gross per film halved in the period with no crossover to pay the debt off.

DC never completed one turn

Justice League arrived after four films and took \$661m, so the loop was reset rather than repaid.

A new viewer joining Marvel now is [joining between payoffs](#), which is the weakest moment the universe has offered since 2012.

DC's best game scores 94; Marvel's best scores 90

Metacritic scores for the best-regarded games from either publisher



What it means

Five of the eight are DC

Four of them are Batman games from one studio, which is the single-character pattern again.

Marvel's strength is recent

Its three highest-rated titles have all appeared since 2018, against DC's peak in 2011.

The margin is small

Four points on a hundred-point aggregate of reviews is not a decisive gap, and both houses clear 90 at the top.

Marvel wins on breadth; DC wins on depth, and both are judgements

What the four preceding pages settle, and how far that settlement reaches

Breadth is Marvel's

The consistency that produced a median critic score of 84 across 37 releases is the same consistency that makes its worst film watchable.

Depth is DC's

The two acting Oscars, the eleven-nomination film and the best-regarded games all came from one director given one character and no slate.

Neither wins the other's ground

Marvel has no All-Star Superman and DC has no Endgame, and no amount of argument converts one into the other.

Four pages of argument, pointing one way

Marvel's achievement is that 37 films share a voice and a world, which no other studio has managed. DC's achievement is that half a dozen of its books and films are the best things anyone has made with these characters, and each of them finishes.

Treat this as **a reader's verdict rather than a finding**: it is argued from named examples, and the examples are the part worth checking.

Where to start

The two entry paths, what each costs in hours, and the conditions that reverse the advice

5

Five films, in order, take a new viewer from Iron Man to Endgame

The shortest Marvel path that still earns the payoff, 11.8 hours of viewing



DC's four strongest films need no order and almost no homework

Four entry points, what each one is, and the viewing each assumes



The Dark Knight, 2008

2.3 h prior

94 on the Tomatometer and two Academy Awards; Batman Begins helps but is not required.



Wonder Woman, 2017

No prior

93 on the Tomatometer and \$823m worldwide; it opens and closes its own story.



Joker, 2019

No prior

Eleven Academy Award nominations, two wins and \$1.08bn, connected to nothing.



Superman, 2025

No prior

Film one of the new continuity, and the only ground floor either house offers.

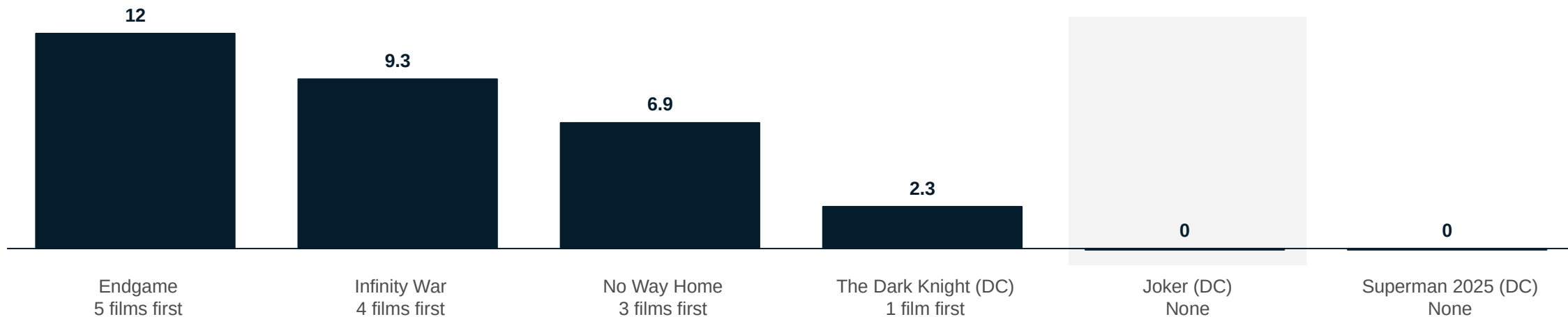
None of the four owes anything to a slate

Three were made outside any shared continuity and the fourth opens a continuity that is one film old, so a reader can take them in any order and stop after one.

Any one of these four is [a complete evening](#), which is the offer Marvel cannot make above the level of its first film.

Marvel's payoffs cost up to twelve hours of homework; DC's cost none

Recommended prior viewing before each film, hours of published running time



What it means

The gap is the whole entry argument

A viewer with one free evening can reach DC's best film immediately and cannot reach Marvel's at all.

Marvel's cheapest payoff is No Way Home

Three films and 6.9 hours, which is still three evenings before the film the recommendation is about.

This is a cost, not a fault

The prior viewing is what Marvel's crossovers are made of, and removing it would remove the payoff with it.

If the reader has one evening rather than one month, [the honest recommendation is DC](#), whatever the commercial record says.

Note: Prior viewing is the author's recommended minimum path; the hours are published theatrical running times.

Source: Published theatrical running times

Eight books open the page side; DC's four need nothing before them

Entry books for both publishers, with length and continuity load

Book or run	Publisher	Length Issues	Continuity	Best for
Watchmen	DC	12	None	One complete argument
All-Star Superman	DC	12	None	The character at his best
Batman: Year One	DC	4	None	One afternoon
The Sandman	DC	75	None	A long finished story
Ultimate Spider-Man	Marvel	133	None	Marvel from scratch
Daredevil, Bendis run	Marvel	55	Light	Crime fiction with a cape
Immortal Hulk	Marvel	50	Moderate	A reader who knows the character
Hickman's Fantastic Four	Marvel	48	Moderate	The shared universe's scale

DC's four are all finite and all self-contained

None of them requires knowing which continuity reset it sits after, which is the practical benefit of a house that keeps starting again.

Marvel's four are runs, not books

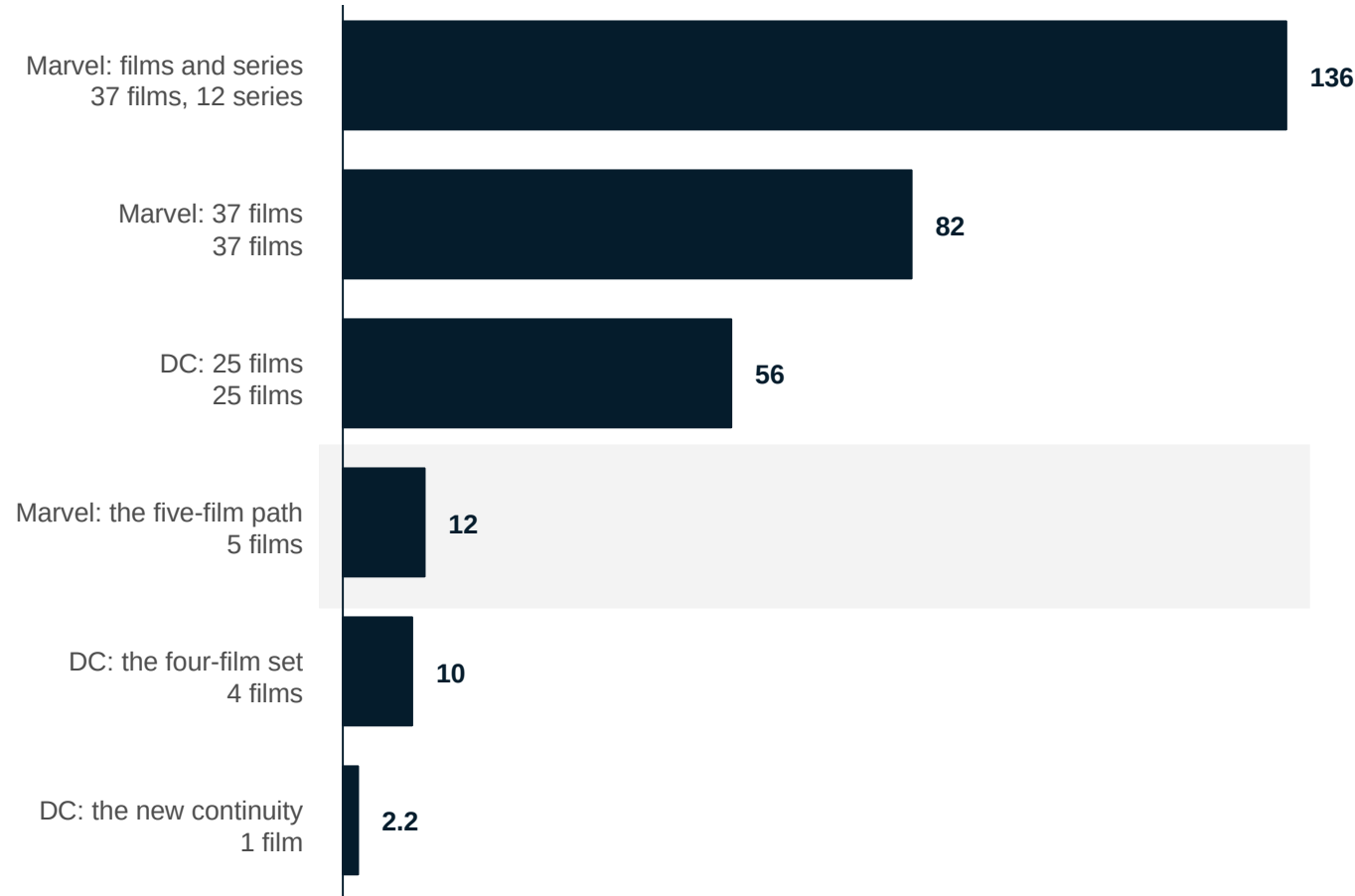
Ultimate Spider-Man alone is 133 issues, which is the page equivalent of the twelve-hour film path.

The medium flips the answer

On screen Marvel is the cheaper first step and DC the expensive one; on the page it is [the other way round](#).

The complete Marvel run costs 136 hours; the useful path costs twelve

Total published running time by definition of completeness, hours



Note: Marvel's series total covers the twelve live-action Disney+ series released from 2021 to 2025.

Source: Published theatrical running times

What it means

Completeness is expensive on both sides

Eighty-two hours of Marvel films is **three and a half days**; adding the twelve live-action series takes it to 136.

The recommended paths cost a tenth of that

Eleven point eight hours for Marvel and ten for DC reach the films the recommendation is actually about.

DC's new continuity is two hours old

A viewer joining now has seen the whole of it after one film, which is the cheapest ground floor either house has offered since 2008.

Four readers, four first steps: two start at DC, two at Marvel

What to do first, second and next, by what the reader is looking for

	One free evening	One free month	A comics reader	A completist
Start with	Joker or The Dark Knight	Iron Man, then The Avengers	All-Star Superman	Iron Man (2008)
Then	The Batman, if the first one landed	The Winter Soldier, then Civil War	Watchmen, then The Sandman	The Avengers, then Phase 2 in order
Next	▪ Superman (2025) for the new continuity ▪ Stop there; nothing is owed	▪ Infinity War and Endgame ▪ Then stop: the loop is open	▪ Ultimate Spider-Man for Marvel ▪ Then Daredevil or Immortal Hulk	▪ Phase 3 entire, then the series ▪ 82 hours of film, 136 with series
House	DC	Marvel	DC first	Marvel

What it means

The evening reader and the comics reader both start at DC

Both want something that finishes, and finishing is what DC's best work does.

The month reader and the completist start at Marvel

Both are buying the accumulation, which is the only thing Marvel sells that DC does not.

Nobody should start at Justice League

DC's one crossover took \$661m against a \$300m budget and scored 39, so the shared-universe route is the one path neither profile takes.

Six conditions reverse this advice; two of them are already moving

What would have to change, where it stands, and which way the answer goes

Condition	Where it stands	Which way it moves
DC's second film lands	Superman took \$615m; slate to 2027	Towards DC on screen
Marvel completes a crossover	None since 2019; two announced	Back to Marvel
The reader has one evening	Depends on the reader	Towards DC
Audience scores preferred	Gap falls to single figures	Towards a tie
DC resets its comics again	A sixth relaunch would follow	Away from DC on the page
Either house wins Best Picture	Two nominations, no wins	Towards the winner

What it means



Two conditions are live right now DC's restart and Marvel's crossover gap are both in motion, and they push the answer in opposite directions.



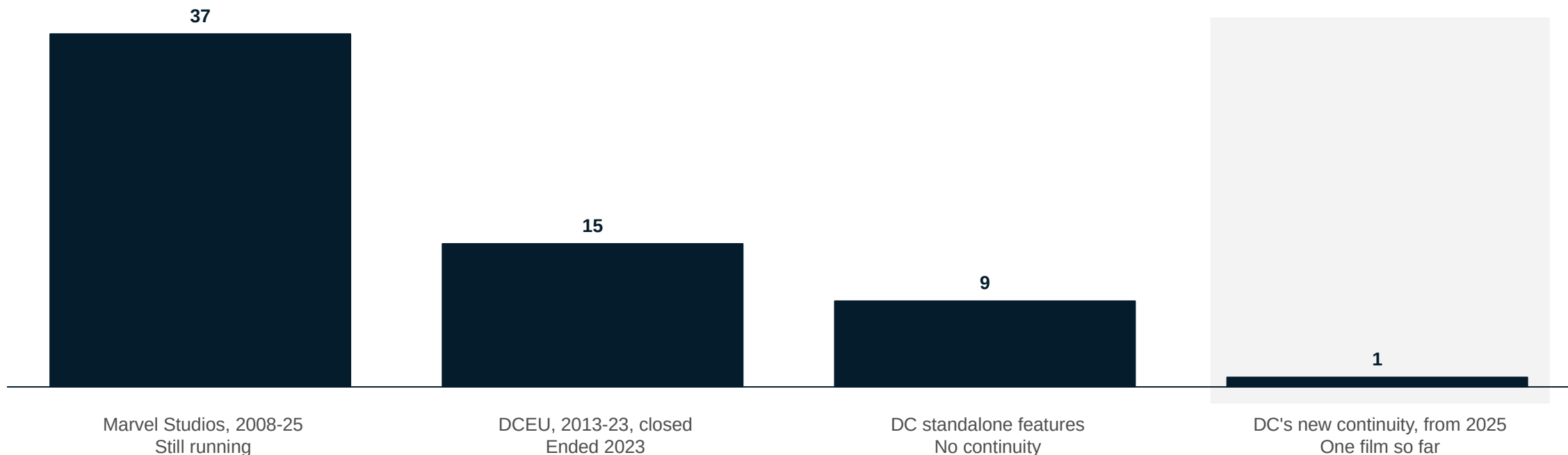
One condition is about the reader How much time is available reverses the screen recommendation on its own, without any new evidence.



The page recommendation is the most stable Only a sixth DC continuity reset would move it, and that would take years to matter to a new reader.

A new viewer joins DC at film one and Marvel at film thirty-eight

Films released into each publisher's current screen continuity, to September 2026



What it means

Only one of these four is a ground floor

DC's new continuity has released a single film, so a viewer joining in 2026 has missed nothing at all.

Marvel's 37 films are an asset and a barrier at once

They are what makes the crossovers work and what makes the entry cost twelve hours.

The closed DCEU is nobody's starting point

Fifteen films that have been superseded are the one run this deck recommends to no reader.

One question sorts the reader: an ending, or a world?

The decision, its two branches, and what each one commits the reader to

You want an ending: take DC

You want a world: take Marvel

Screen: The Dark Knight or Joker tonight, with no prior viewing at all

Screen: Iron Man, then four more films to Endgame, 11.8 hours in order

Page: All-Star Superman then Watchmen, 24 issues, both complete

Page: Ultimate Spider-Man, then the main line, unbroken since 1961

Total commitment before you can judge the house: about five hours

Total commitment before the payoff arrives: about twelve hours

What you give up: nothing compounds, and no later film pays this one off

What you give up: the first evening is set-up rather than argument

The branches are not exclusive

None of the four DC entry films requires anything afterwards, so an evening spent on the left branch costs nothing towards the right one. The reverse is not true: the Marvel path only pays off at its end, so a reader who stops after two films has bought the set-up and none of the argument, and a reader who starts at Endgame has bought the argument without the set-up.

Starting at DC costs nothing towards Marvel later.

Three steps this week, none of them costing more than three hours

How to test the recommendation before committing to either house

1 Watch The Dark Knight

2.5 h

DC's highest-regarded film, no prior viewing, and the cheapest test of whether the house suits you.

2 Read All-Star Superman

3 h

Twelve issues, complete, and the best argument for what DC's characters are for.

3 Watch Iron Man

2.1 h

The start of the Marvel path. If it works, four more films reach Endgame; if not, you have lost an evening.

Why these three and in this order

The first two are the cheapest complete things either house has made, and the third is the only Marvel film that works with nothing before it. If the first two land and the third does not, the page answer is DC and the screen answer is DC as well.

Seven and a half hours settles a choice the full commitment prices at 136.

Three things to take away

- 1** **Marvel has won every commercial measure since 2013; DC has won every measure of recognition per release.**
- 2** **The screen answer is Marvel and the page answer is DC, and neither is a compromise.**
- 3** **Seven and a half hours of watching and reading settles the choice for good.**

Appendix

The workings behind the story

6

Every source used, and what each one can and cannot support

Basis for the measured pages in sections one, two, three and five

Source	Used for	Pages	What it cannot support
Box Office Mojo	Gross by film, year, phase and franchise	6-14	Profit, admissions or inflation-adjusted totals
Reported production budgets	The 2.5x break-even multiple	10-11	Audited studio margin; budgets are not audited
Published running times	Entry cost and completion cost	31, 33	Whether the hours are worth spending
Rotten Tomatoes, critics	Score distributions and rankings	16-17	Quality: it counts opinions, not films
Rotten Tomatoes, audiences	The critic-audience gap	20	A representative audience; scores self-select
Academy Awards database	Competitive wins and nominations	18-19	Merit: campaigns decide what is nominated
Metacritic, lead platform	Game scores	27	Sales, playtime or player numbers
First appearances and relaunches	Founding sequence and resets	3-4	Whether a reset improved the books
Author's judgement, marked	Sections four and five	22-28	Anything at all: it is argued, not counted

A gross figure cannot be asked about profit, a critic aggregate cannot be asked about quality, and where no instrument exists the page argues instead of counting.

Marvel's eleven billion-dollar films, with budget and multiple (1/2)

Marvel Studios releases above \$1bn worldwide, lifetime gross

Film	Year	Budget \$m	Worldwide gross \$m	Multiple x budget
Avengers: Endgame	2019	356	2799	7.9
Avengers: Infinity War	2018	316	2048	6.5
Spider-Man: No Way Home	2021	200	1912	9.6
The Avengers	2012	220	1519	6.9
Avengers: Age of Ultron	2015	365	1403	3.8
Black Panther	2018	200	1349	6.7
Total	12103	1,657		41.4

Worldwide gross (\$m, common scale 0 to 3000)

The lowest multiple here is Age of Ultron at 3.8 and the highest No Way Home at 9.6, and DC's four billion-dollar films sit in the same band: the break-even comparison is decided by the films that never reached \$1bn, not by these.

Marvel's eleven billion-dollar films, with budget and multiple (2/2)

Marvel Studios releases above \$1bn worldwide, lifetime gross

Film	Year	Budget \$m	Worldwide gross \$m	Multiple x budget
Deadpool & Wolverine	2024	200	1338	6.7
Iron Man 3	2013	200	1215	6.1
Captain America: Civil War	2016	250	1153	4.6
Spider-Man: Far From Home	2019	160	1132	7.1
Captain Marvel	2019	175	1128	6.4
Total	10091	985		30.9

Worldwide gross (\$m, common scale 0 to 1500)

The lowest multiple here is Age of Ultron at 3.8 and the highest No Way Home at 9.6, and DC's four billion-dollar films sit in the same band: the break-even comparison is decided by the films that never reached \$1bn, not by these.

Four terms this deck uses in a narrower sense than usual

Definitions applied consistently across every page and figure



Marvel Studios

The 37 films released by Marvel Studios from 2008. It excludes Fox's X-Men and Sony's Spider-Man films, which use Marvel characters under separate arrangements.



The DCEU

The fifteen films from Man of Steel in 2013 to Aquaman and the Lost Kingdom in 2023, which shared one continuity and have now been closed.



DC standalone features

Nine Warner Bros. DC films made outside any shared continuity, from Batman Begins in 2005 to Joker: Folie a Deux in 2024. Superman (2025) opens a new continuity and is counted separately.



The break-even multiple

Worldwide gross divided by reported production budget. A film is conventionally taken to break even near 2.5 times budget, which is a rule of thumb rather than an accounting result.